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**Psychometrics through Projective Tests:
Indicators of Psychological Truth in the Child**
القياس النفسي من خلال الاختبارات الإسقاطية :
مؤشرات دالة على الحقيقة النفسية عند الطفل

Dr- Remmas Rachida Zohra

Lectuer A, University of Saida, Dr. Moulay Tahar, Faculty of Social Sciences and Humanities,
Departement of psychology and Educational science,
rachidazohra.remmas@univ-saida.dz

د-ة رماس رشيدة الزهرة

أستاذة محاضرة "أ"، جامعة سعيدة الدكتور مولاي الطاهر،

كلية العلوم الاجتماعية والإنسانية ، قسم علم النفس وعلوم التربية

rachidazohra.remmas@univ-saida.dz

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Abstract:

The methods and quality of interventions carried out by specialists during a child's psychological evaluation differ significantly from those used with adults or adolescents. This distinction arises from the child's unique psychological characteristics and developmental stage. For this reason, projective psychological tools that use simple and play-based expressions are among the most effective techniques. They provide key indicators of the child's psychological reality and reveal areas of inner conflict. This article highlights the value of projective psychological tests, particularly the Family Test

and story-based techniques, which are easy to administer and interpret. Such tools help psychologists simplify diagnosis, access the child's psychological reality, and identify internal conflicts, especially in relation to parental dynamics and family interactions.

Keywords: Projective psychological tests, child psychology, family drawing test, psycho-diagnostic assessment, psychogamy conflict.

المخلص:

تختلف منهجية ونوعية التدخلات التي يقوم بها المختص أثناء الفحص النفسي للطفل عن تلك عند الراشد وحتى المراهق، كونها تتماشى مع الخصوصية النفسية للطفل ومرحلة النمو النفسي الذي يوجد فيها. فذلك ما يجعل الاختبارات النفسية الإسقاطية ذات التعبيرات الخطية والتي تعتمد على اللعب من الوسائل الفعالة التي تقدم مؤشرات هامة عن الحقيقة النفسية للطفل وتكشف مواطن الصراع.

يوضح هذا المقال أهمية الاختبارات النفسية الإسقاطية خاصة منها اختبار العائلة والقصص التي تعتبر سهلة المنال والتطبيق، بحيث تسهل على المختص النفسي عملية التشخيص، تمكنه من فهم الحقيقة النفسية وتحدد مواطن الصراع في إطار ارتباطه بالاستثمارات الموضوعية خاصة منه الوالدية.

الكلمات المفتاحية: الاختبارات النفسية الإسقاطية، علم نفس الطفل، اختبار رسم العائلة، التقييم التشخيصي النفسي، الصراع النفسي.

1. INTRODUCTION

Diagnosis in clinical psychology aims to assess the various dimensions of personality as reflected through mental and emotional behavior. The interview technique is not limited to describing the individual and their problems; rather, it seeks to understand them within their personal linguistic and environmental context and individual frame of reference (Wildlocher, 2006, p. 12). Through this interaction, the specialist attempts to uncover the dynamics

of internal conflicts and the relational and functional features of personality as expressed in contact with the environment.

This is referred to as a person's *inner psychological truth*—a reflection of the internal psychological functioning directly linked to external behaviors. Understanding this psychological functioning (*le fonctionnement psychique*) is one of the primary goals of the clinical psychologist. It is crucial to identify both the dynamics of each individual's psychological system and

their personal strengths and potential (*sespotentiels*). During the psychological assessment, the individual engages in a complex mental and emotional process that fluctuates between the pressures of external reality and those of the inner world, activating perceptions and internal conflicts.

In the course of the psychological examination, the psychologist uses the clinical interview to explore both real and imaginary actions (*les actions réelles et imaginaires*). This helps to access the person's perceptual world (*le sujet*). As Bydlowski (2006, p. 12) explains, the individual's speech "is not a description of ideas but the linguistic expression of the act of thinking."

Research in clinical psychology therefore cannot be confined to emotional aspects alone, as these are insufficient for understanding the entire psychological functioning. Unconscious representations (*les représentations inconscientes*) and conscious experiences are both related to external behaviors and emotional perceptions. The person's expression often takes the form of an ambiguous message, and the psychologist's role is to uncover its meaning and decode the symbolic content that reflects the individual's inner dynamics.

Psychological content is essentially emotional; however, certain emotional elements do not reach the level of awareness until resistances are lifted. The unconscious is "a psychological system that includes signs, mechanisms, and capricious energy, perceptions and delusions associated with caprice and desires" (Laplanche & Pontalis, 1967).

Analytical theory approaches these manifestations from the perspective of conflict. Generally, there is a relative balance between repressed and repressing

tendencies. Yet, when a psychological or physical event occurs in daily life, this balance may be disturbed, threatening stability through the "return of the repressed" (*le retour du refoulé*). These repressed tendencies do not emerge as they are in the unconscious. Instead, they appear as signs of anxiety, managed by the psychological system through the formation of a "compromise solution" (*un compromis*), which allows the ego and unconscious to meet their emotional and psychological needs.

When considering psychological truth, the psychologist must adopt a holistic approach. All dimensions of psychological life—family relations, identity, school, professional aspects, and other personal variables—must be linked to both unconscious and conscious representations. Psychological truth can only be understood within the dynamic interaction of these elements.

For this reason, projective techniques are essential tools that help confirm and support interpretations of unconscious data revealed during clinical interviews. Using projective tests to understand an individual's psychological functioning is therefore a clinical necessity. The projective situation provides the subject with the opportunity to express themselves through ambiguous stimuli that activate perceptual and representational experiences. This process produces responses that "mobilize images and fantasies and reduce the subject's level of inhibition" (Chabert, 1983, p. 96).

In the psychological examination of children, it is difficult to rely solely on direct verbal expression during interviews. Children often struggle to articulate their thoughts and emotions and to understand their own inner states. Speaking directly

about themselves can be challenging, not only because of limited expressive abilities but also due to underdeveloped processes of psychological elaboration (*l'élaboration psychique*) and symbolization. These limitations prevent them from clearly recognizing and expressing their emotions beyond vague feelings of anxiety, fear, or general distress.

This raises an important question: How can projective tests reveal the child's psychological functioning and help the specialist understand the child's inner truth, especially when precise information can only be known by the child? Another question emerges as well: What are the simplest projective tests that allow specialists to diagnose children's psychological states using reliable and observable indicators?

Projective tests allow the emergence of expressions that might not appear during a standard clinical interview. As Chabert (1983, p. 96) explains, the projective setting "gives the subject the possibility of linking and speaking based on ambiguous means, so that its implicit cognitive specifications activate the field of sensory and representational experiences by giving answers. These answers are recorded in a context that mobilizes images and fantasies and lowers the subject's level of inhibition."

For this reason, psychologists often use techniques situated within a play context (*un contexte ludique*). According to Winnicott (1971), children are "most serious when they are playing" because play allows them to express the deepest parts of themselves. By incorporating play activities, the psychologist creates an essential communicative space where the child can express themselves—verbally, symbolically, or non-verbally—even in the absence of

sufficient linguistic or expressive competence. Through play, the child's psychological truth becomes visible.

Play includes any activity in which the child participates. Through imaginative engagement, the child consciously expresses part of their personality and unconsciously reveals their inner psychological reality. These expressions often take linear forms—such as drawings or storytelling—that reflect both the conscious and unconscious dimensions of the self.

2. Drawing in the Psychological Assessment of the Child

The child's drawing is closely related to body image and interpersonal relationships. According to Winnicott (1975), the child internalizes (*intériorise*) relationships with significant figures. Through this relational pattern, the child builds perceptions of self and others, which later shape future relationships within the external world.

Drawing has strong projective value. In every drawing, the child projects aspects of their body image, self-perception, and inner psychological state. Drawing thus becomes a key diagnostic and therapeutic tool. It transcends linguistic barriers and unconscious resistance, opening a symbolic space where internal truths can emerge. Through these drawings, the child reveals fantasies, needs, and frustrations linked to both objective and narcissistic aspects of the psyche.

By connecting the implicit meaning with the visible content, the psychologist can decode the symbolic expressions present in the drawing. According to Chouvier (2012), drawing performs three essential functions:

a. The Expressive Function (*la représentativité*)

Graphic expression allows the projection of internal states that cannot be consciously controlled or directly verbalized. These expressions emerge spontaneously and resist regulation, reflecting impulsive emotional content.

b. The Function of Meaning (*la fonction de signifiante*)

Each line or graphic element in the drawing carries representative meaning. Its significance depends on the emotional charge associated with it. The specialist must therefore identify areas of conflict through these emotional traces, observable in the form, pressure, and rhythm of the lines.

c. The Relational Function (*la fonction relationnelle*)

Drawing also serves a transformative function involving form, content, and meaning. It reflects the projections the child makes onto their relational environment and onto the psychologist. Through this relational process, drawing becomes an intermediary between the child's inner world and external reality.

3. The Family Drawing Test

The child's body image gradually develops through relational experiences and emotional investments in parental figures. These early attachments play a central role in shaping how the child perceives both self and others. As a result, the *Family Drawing Test* provides a projective means of exploring how the child symbolically represents family members, relationships, and associated emotions. It reveals inner conflicts through their connection with relational investments and family dynamics.

From this perspective, the *Family Drawing Test* is designed as a projective

technique in which the child draws an imaginary family closely connected to their real one. This approach grants expressive freedom and creates a psychological outlet through which the child can project internal perceptions of the family, reduce anxiety, and release unconscious fantasies. The drawing allows the psychologist to gather valuable information about the family's structure and the organization of both its visible and hidden relationships.

The interpretation of the drawing follows a structured classification framework that includes emotional, cognitive, and relational dimensions (Jourdan-Ionescu&Lachance, 2000). During the activity, the specialist carefully observes and records the child's emotions, gestures, and behaviors throughout the drawing process. Each of these manifestations holds symbolic meaning that can reflect unconscious emotional states. Particular attention is paid when the child displays strong emotions or specific reactions while drawing certain family members, as these expressions can serve as meaningful indicators of underlying psychological conflicts.

4. The Importance of Play Activity for the Child (*L'activité du jeu*)

According to Winnicott (1971), play is a *space of freedom*—a *transitional space* (*un espace transitionnel*) that enables the child to externalize internal elements of their psychological reality. Expression through play provides valuable insights that begin with how the child approaches and engages with the activity. Every action, emotion, and expression—whether joy, sadness, confusion, or anger—reflects a narrative form of symbolic communication that reveals the child's internal world.

Projective story tests fall within this framework of play. Freud (1967) proposed that by analyzing the symbolic meanings within fairy tales and children's stories, psychologists can uncover repressed desires and the inner conflicts that drive behavior. These stories, much like dreams, carry both explicit and implicit meanings within their evolving narrative dynamics.

Using storytelling as a play-based projective technique allows the child to meet internal needs and satisfy repressed desires. When a child constructs an imaginary story that originates from the unconscious, they create symbolic scenarios through which unmet desires can be fulfilled indirectly. Winnicott (1971) explains that the story, as a transitional form, occupies a space between truth and fiction. This *play space* provides a safe outlet for repressed wishes, which the psychologist can explore as part of the diagnostic and therapeutic process. Such stories reveal significant indicators of the child's concerns, developmental level, attitudes, and behavioral tendencies.

Bettelheim (1976) emphasizes that the structure of a child's story—including the sequence of events, repetitions, similarities, and other compositional features—reflects the organization of the self. Storytelling thus holds both diagnostic and therapeutic value, as it allows for analysis of the symbolic meanings embedded in both manifest and latent content.

For this reason, the use of storytelling in analytical psychology serves as a projective test that helps interpret the initial situation, the narrative's development, the treatment of its main theme, and its essential components. The conclusion provided by the child after the sequence of events is especially meaningful. The psychologist must pay close attention to this ending, as it

often holds symbolic value related to the child's psychological dynamics and the inner mechanisms employed to resolve conflicts.

The *Royer (1999) Storytelling Test* is a projective diagnostic tool composed of twenty-one stories designed for children aged seven to thirteen. It aims to identify psychological and developmental issues characteristic of different stages of childhood. The test focuses particularly on:

- Birth trauma
- Emotional frustrations (*les frustrations affectives*) and their sensory associations, including abandonment (*l'abandon*), sibling rivalry (*la rivalitéfraternelle*), feelings of inferiority (*le sentiment d'infériorité*), and problems linked to the oral stage
- Affective-motor difficulties, such as walking and control of bodily functions
- Sexual-affective problems
- The child's relational and environmental context

In this test, the child is invited to continue and complete short story prompts. After narrating the events and providing an ending, the psychologist analyzes the story's content according to the child's age, developmental stage, and psychological dynamics. The test is experienced by the child as a form of play, opening a gateway into their imaginative world.

Through this projective method, the child projects emotional and cognitive representations of the self across three temporal dimensions—the past, the present, and the future—thereby expressing both conscious and unconscious elements of psychological functioning.

The *Royer Storytelling Test* serves primarily as a diagnostic tool, providing results that enrich the clinical assessment

process. The following clinical example illustrates how projective tests complement interviews by producing in-depth diagnostic hypotheses that inform psychological care strategies. These cases concern schoolchildren between eight and eleven years of age who experienced emotional difficulties and learning problems. Their psychological assessment was based on projective techniques, particularly the *Family Drawing Test* and the *story Test*.

4. 1 Case 1: Walid(11 years old)

Walid, an eleven-year-old boy, was once an active and motivated student. However, by his second year of intermediate school, he had become disengaged, inattentive, and less focused in class. Although his behavior remained calm, he neglected his homework and displayed a noticeable decline in academic performance. This deterioration was inconsistent with his intellectual potential, as noted by teachers who described him as intelligent, deserving, and in need of emotional support.

During initial interviews, Walid appeared withdrawn, silent, and uncooperative, responding only with short, minimal answers. In later sessions, he claimed that he was studying diligently but was struggling with memory problems. However, results from *La Figure Complexe de Rey* test revealed no memory deficit. On the contrary, they demonstrated solid retention and recall abilities at various memory levels.

Further insights emerged during an interview with his mother. She described the father's emotional absence following his remarriage and the birth of another child. The father's new family situation caused emotional neglect toward Walid, who no longer received attention from his paternal relatives.

The interpretation of Walid's *Family Drawing Test* results revealed several key psychological indicators:

- A pronounced sense of inferiority and significant self-directed aggression, particularly in relation to his father.
- A distorted representation of the father figure, depicted as distant and faceless.
- Anxiety linked to a deep sense of guilt that threatened the stability of the ego.
- The presence of *castration anxiety* and disruptions in the process of identification, reflecting feelings of rejection and insecurity.
- Strong emotional investments accompanied by persistent anxiety.
- Clear expressions of rejection associated with a high degree of emotional tension.

Additionally, Walid excluded himself from the family drawing, symbolizing detachment and alienation. The representation of the mother figure appeared distorted and ambivalent, suggesting contradictory emotional feelings toward her.

• Fluctuation in Self-Perceptions

When presented with the test results and after discussing the child's complex psychological situation, characterized by feelings of threatened emotional investment and a sense of guilt, it became clear that the issue extends beyond mere parental absence. The mother reported that the child's father severed all ties with him following her repeated attempts to persuade him to acknowledge paternity, as she had given birth to a newborn resulting from a long-term extramarital relationship.

She further explained that Walid learned of this situation after overhearing a conversation at his father's family home, where he had been staying and receiving

their sympathy. However, that relationship also ended after his father's subsequent marriage, as the father continued living in his family home.

Walid avoids discussing this matter with his mother and remains withdrawn and silent, which reflects a deep inner suffering and persistent emotional distress.

4. 2Case2:Hanan (10 years old)

Hanan, aged ten, was enrolled in the fourth year of primary school. Her mother sought psychological assistance due to academic difficulties, memory and attention problems, and regressive behaviors such as playing with her school supplies, talking to them, and tearing her notebooks.

The mother revealed that Hanan was adopted at birth. She had previously adopted another daughter (now 21 years old), who learned about her adoption at 18 without apparent distress. Hanan's biological mother, who is also her aunt, has maintained close contact, frequently inviting her to visit and spend nights with her. The adoptive mother suspected that Hanan had learned the truth about her origins, possibly from her biological mother, though the matter was never directly addressed.

In the first interview, Hanan appeared energetic yet distracted, showing good adaptability to new situations. She spoke at length about her studies, friends, and extended family. In subsequent sessions, she repeatedly mentioned her uncle's family and his young son, who resembles her—a possible indirect reference to her biological kinship.

The family drawing revealed:

- Rich imagination, used as an escape mechanism from anxiety and emotional insecurity.

- Regressive tendencies and feelings of rejection.

- Affective ambivalence toward the mother figure, emotionally significant but conflicted.

- Neglect of the father figure, both in the drawing and in conversation.

- Fluctuating self-perception and anxiety with disintegrative patterns tied to guilt threatening ego stability.

Although these findings were insightful, they did not fully clarify Hanan's internal psychological reality regarding the adoption. Therefore, the Royer Storytelling Test (Test des Contes) was administered.

This story addresses themes of adoption and belonging. Hanan's version described a bird leaving its chick with another bird. She assigned her biological mother's name to the first bird and her adoptive mother's name to the second. She then altered the plot, stating that the second bird was not a friend but an aunt, insisting that the chick must return to its real mother to live and play with her siblings, especially her younger brother, "who looks like her." The tone expressed fear and confusion, symbolizing her internal conflict between attachment and identity.

Hanan's narrative projection reveals an unconscious awareness of her adoption, alongside deep ambivalence between loyalty to her adoptive mother and longing for her biological roots. Her fantasy reconstruction—"the chick returning to its real mother"—reflects a repressed wish to integrate these divided attachments and resolve her identity conflict.

Both cases demonstrate the diagnostic and therapeutic value of projective techniques in child assessment. Through symbolic representation in drawing and storytelling, the child expresses unconscious conflicts, desires, and anxieties that are otherwise inaccessible through direct

questioning.

These tools, used alongside interviews, help clinicians formulate comprehensive psychodynamic hypotheses, guiding effective psychological care and intervention strategies.

4.3 Case 3: Jawad (9 years old)

Jawad, aged nine, is the second son in a family composed of a stay-at-home mother and a working father. From the first encounter, Jawad presented with marked depressive features—slow movements, lack of animation, and a rare smile.

Both parents expressed concern about his declining academic performance and lack of motivation, which they considered inconsistent with his high intellectual potential.

During the initial interviews, Jawad appeared withdrawn, shy, and reluctant to engage in conversation. He seemed preoccupied with objects on the desk, avoiding eye contact and verbal expression. However, when introduced to the computer during one session, he displayed clear interest and strong cognitive abilities, using the medium as a safe platform for communication.

Administered during the fourth session, the Family Drawing Test revealed several significant indicators:

- Lack of willpower and enthusiasm, reflecting a state of internal inhibition.
- Feelings of inferiority and low self-confidence.
- Punitive guilt, where guilt feelings erase errors yet intensify anxiety.
- Perceived rejection by others and oppositional tendencies linked with a search for protection.
- Emotional ambivalence toward the mother, marked by both attachment and tension.

- The faces drawn were vague and indistinct, suggesting difficulty in emotional expression and inhibition of affect.

- The light pressure of the pencil and dashed, nearly invisible lines pointed to fragile self-esteem and avoidance of direct emotional expression.

- The minimal use of color reflected emotional flatness and depressive tendencies.

The Royer Test of Stories further illuminated Jawad's internal conflicts and affective representations. His stories revealed:

- A deep sense of guilt accompanied by punitive tendencies.
- Primitive anxieties and regressive mechanisms associated with insecurity in relational investment.
- Feelings of inferiority and negative self-representation.

The content of the story is as follows:

"The sauce flopped in the egg and struggled to get out. He got tired of all that. After much effort, the egg began to crack, so he tried to come out. But when he did, the shell pressed him; it was sharp and hurt his head. Even though he had brothers, he always played alone, away from them. While he was playing, he hurt himself, and his mother did not come to treat his wound. When it rained, he tried to find shelter under the shell."

The symbolic imagery in Jawad's story suggests themes of birth trauma, maternal withdrawal, and emotional abandonment. When these interpretations were shared with the mother, particularly regarding the birth experience, she was astonished to recall that Jawad's delivery had indeed required the use of forceps, which the child unconsciously symbolized as "the sharp shell that hurt his head."

The mother also acknowledged experiencing a marital crisis around that period, during which she considered separating from her husband, planning to leave the two sons with the father and keep only the youngest daughter with her. Jawad, who had been emotionally closest to his mother, was deeply affected by this crisis, developing depressive symptoms shortly thereafter.

The projective tests confirmed the diagnostic hypotheses established through the interviews:

- Jawad's internal world is dominated by feelings of guilt, rejection, and insecurity.
- His maternal representation is ambivalent, both cherished and emotionally distant.
- The paternal image appears weak, lacking authority and protective capacity.
- The depressive state emerges as a defense against internalized conflicts related to maternal separation and emotional deprivation.

In summary, the integration of the Family Drawing Test and Royer Storytelling Test provided a comprehensive understanding of Jawad's psychological functioning, revealing that his academic difficulties are not cognitive in origin but rooted in affective and relational disturbances. These findings highlight the critical role of projective tools in linking the child's internal reality to external family dynamics and guiding appropriate psychotherapeutic intervention.

5. Summary of Cases

Across the three clinical cases, the difficulties of verbal expression and the deficiencies in psychological elaboration (*élaboration psychique*) emerged as major obstacles preventing the children from becoming aware of their own emotions. Their psychological suffering was deeply rooted in

complex and conflictual family environments, where affective communication was often fragile or disrupted.

The clinical interviews initially revealed limited parental openness, as crucial information was often withheld intentionally or unconsciously, which made it difficult to access the children's internal realities.

The Family Drawing Test proved to be an invaluable tool for understanding each child's pattern of relational investment and their self-perception in relation to their family members, especially the parents and emotionally significant figures. This test also provided rich data on the psychological dynamics, anxiety patterns, and relational representations within family structures.

In all three cases, the forms of anxiety identified through projective drawings were closely linked to relational and parental investments, which appeared threatening to the ego. The projective material revealed psychological difficulties arising from disturbances in parental roles, relational ruptures, and conflicts of identification, all of which affected the construction of identity. Moreover, these conflicts reflected a dominance of primitive anxieties (such as disintegration or castration anxiety) that hindered emotional stability.

The Storytelling Test further complemented the findings by offering a safe and symbolic means of expression, allowing the children to verbalize inner experiences that were previously inaccessible. Through this method, the clinician was able to access deeply regressive tendencies, primal anxieties, and the unconscious conflicts underlying their behaviors, thus facilitating a more accurate understanding of the child's internal psychological truth.

6. CONCLUSION

The psychological truth of the individual arises from a dynamic interplay among multiple dimensions. According to Edmond (2005), a person's self-perception is shaped by the interaction between

conscious mental representations and unconscious processes, forming a multidimensional and interrelated structure that integrates drives, affects, and perceptions.

In psychological assessment, the clinician aims to interpret the subject's verbal and non-verbal expressions, decoding both content and symbolic indicators. The objective is to understand the psychological processes and dynamics in relation to observable external behaviors.

However, the psychological examination of the child poses unique challenges. The child's limited verbal capacity and immature mechanisms of psychological elaboration make it difficult to reach the level of expression necessary for diagnostic formulation. The clinician must therefore establish links between the child's external reality (observable behavior) and internal reality (psychological functioning), taking into account all mental, emotional, and relational dimensions.

In most cases, anxiety and fear dominate the child's internal world, inhibiting adaptive and cognitive functions. Many children suffer from underdeveloped capacities for symbolization and emotional awareness, which prevent them from recognizing and expressing their feelings. Thus, the psychologist's role is to help the child achieve awareness of his or her emotions and conflicts, facilitating understanding and transformation.

Projective techniques based on drawing and play offer a privileged means to access the child's internal world. These tools enable the clinician to explore defensivemechanisms, relational patterns, emotional frustrations, conflicts, and levels of affective maturity consistent with the child's developmental stage.

From a therapeutic perspective, such projective activities not only aid in diagnosis but also contribute to the construction of a secure therapeutic relationship. Through these creative and symbolic expressions, the child gradually strengthens psychological elaboration, becomes more aware of emotional experiences, and develops the capacity to understand and overcome internal obstacles, thereby fostering adaptation, growth, and creative potential.

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